

slip into a cycle of panicking and frantically paying off as much as you can, then falling short in your monthly budget and having to borrow again. It's so hard to manage your finances in a calm and healthy way when you're acting out of fear and panic most of the time. Solid spending and repayment habits will really help you to regain control, and apply a slightly more clinical, neutral approach to managing debt.

If you use your credit card for small purchases throughout the month, which are affordable, it's a great idea to set up a direct debit to collect the full amount when you get paid – like with saving, the sooner this amount leaves your account, the more accurately you can plan your monthly finances. The danger with making payments ad-hoc is that you might get busy and miss one, while the risk with paying the minimum and letting balances run over from month to month is that the amount you owe will creep up and up, and you'll be left with an anxiety-inducing bill after a few months. It's a good idea to make a habit of checking your balance regularly, so that you don't end up with a nasty surprise six months down the line.

If you're using your credit card to spread the cost of a bigger payment, divide the amount that you owe by the number of months that you want to pay it off in, and make sure that you have a direct debit set up for that amount, also on the first of each month, or whenever you get paid. If you're self-employed without a monthly salary, it's still a really good idea to keep your payment dates consistent – having a regular